

Chicago Tribune



\$4.00 | TUESDAY, SEPTEMBER 15, 2026 | CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Justices reject mail-in ballots request

Trump's effort ahead of midterm elections fails at Supreme Court

By Lindsay Whitehurst
ASSOCIATED PRESS

WASHINGTON — The Supreme Court on Monday rejected President Donald Trump's bid to restrict mail ballots for the midterm elections, capping a flurry of last-minute legal action with voting already underway.

The decision allows states to continue sending out mail ballots under the same processes they have used for years. Justices Samuel Alito and Clarence Thomas publicly dissented from the brief order.

The Trump administration had asked the court — once again at the center of a roiling political controversy — to clear the way for restrictions before the pivotal November contests for control of Congress. The case has major implications because nearly one-third of the country votes by mail.

The Supreme Court majority did not detail its reasoning, as is typical on the high court's emergency docket. Alito, meanwhile, said in the dissent that the Postal Service "has broad authority to regulate the mail" and likely does have the power to enforce Trump's restrictions.

Justice Brett Kavanaugh agreed the restrictions should not go into effect for the midterms but indicated he might rule in favor of the Trump administration if the issue comes back before the court.

Election officials have said there

was simply no way to carry out a complete overhaul in the weeks before the midterms. Alabama, North Carolina and Wisconsin began sending mail ballots to voters over the past week while the new system was still not active.

The Trump administration plan would require states to adopt a uniform envelope style and submit lists of eligible voters to an online portal. The Postal Service could refuse to deliver ballots to states that didn't comply.

A whistleblower report, though,

said the postal system's requirements could lead to millions of mail ballots never being sent, because the portal wasn't properly built and a single bar code error could result in an entire batch of ballots being tossed out.

Democratic state officials and voting rights groups challenged the restrictions in court, arguing that the president has no constitutional authority to set election rules that would "virtually eliminate mail

See **VOTING** on Page A6

City panel backs more funds to settle suits

The \$13.75 million sum is tied to ex-cop's alleged misconduct

By Jake Sheridan
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Even though Cook County's top prosecutor maintained that two men are guilty of a horrific double-murder despite certificates of innocence, Chicago taxpayers could soon pay them \$13.75 million to settle their police misconduct lawsuits after aldermen advanced a pair of deals Monday.

The City Council Finance Committee recommended Gabriel Solache and Arturo DeLeon-Reyes get the deals to resolve their lawsuits alleging ex-Det. Reynaldo Guevara landed them in prison with false confessions extracted with deceit and beatings.

The two men were convicted in 2000 of a brutal double murder and kidnapping, but have since received certificates of innocence, alongside dozens of other Chicagoans investigated by the disgraced Guevara.

Separate juries convicted the men of fatally stabbing Mariano Soto, 43, and his wife, Jacinta, 35, and kidnapping their two children in a plot prosecutors originally said was motivated by a woman's desire for a baby.

The woman, Adriana Mejia, who allegedly planned the attack in order to steal the couple's 2-month-old daughter, is serving a life sentence in state prison.

Mejia, who was said to be related to DeLeon-Reyes and a friend of Solache's, was alleged to have been faking a pregnancy. Mejia initially told police she was there when DeLeon-Reyes stabbed the victims, but denied Solache was involved, Law Department attorney Jessica Felker told aldermen during the meeting. DeLeon-Reyes then implicated Solache, she added.

But the two men's confessions came amid circumstances that

See **LAWSUITS** on Page A6



The Brandon Road Lock and Dam along the Des Plaines River in Joliet on July 31. **E. JASON WAMBSGANS/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Work resumes on project to keep invasive carp out

After construction pause, Army Corps restarts Brandon Road initiative

By Adriana Pérez
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

More than a month after the U.S. Army Corps of Engineers halted work on the Brandon Road Lock and Dam near Joliet, part of a \$1.15 billion project to keep invasive carp out of the Great Lakes, the agency announced last week it would resume construction.

The Army Corps' Rock Island District — the main federal sponsor — issued a stop-work order on

July 24 "without explanation or warning," advocates say, except to say the project was "under administrative review." Just three weeks later, the Illinois Department of Natural Resources said several hundred small silver carp had been discovered only 80 miles from Lake Michigan in the Illinois River, further upstream than routine monitoring had found the invasive fish since 2010.

The location indicates spawning activity may have occurred

even closer to the lake, which advocates with the Alliance for the Great Lakes call a "troubling sign of an establishing population" and "shows a higher risk of invasion" than the mere presence of adult fish.

President Donald Trump had previously directed federal agencies to carry the project on the Des Plaines River forward with "maximum speed and efficiency."

The Army Corps did not respond to a request for comment

about the pause.

The Brandon Road Interbasin Project, which began construction in 2025, is the culmination of decades-long bipartisan efforts between Illinois, Michigan and the federal government to stop the invasive fish, which pose a significant threat to the native species and aquatic ecosystems of the Great Lakes, as well as its billion-dollar fishing and boating

See **CARP** on Page A7

INSIDE



Bears wide receiver Jahdae Walker celebrates after a special teams play resulting in a turnover Sunday.

JOHN J. KIM/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Bears reflect on win in Week 1 rout

While the Bears scored 59 points in a Week 1 victory over the Panthers, coach Ben Johnson isn't ringing the alarm about the secondary after the team yielded 37 points. **Sports**

ELECTION 2026

Trump backs Bailey for Illinois governor

GOP candidate has sought to distance himself from president

By Rick Pearson
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

President Donald Trump has endorsed Darren Bailey for governor, a move that undercuts the Republican nominee's attempts to distance himself from a president unpopular in Illinois and whose backing contributed to Bailey's loss to Democrat JB Pritzker in 2022.

"I've already endorsed him. I'm all for Bailey," Trump told reporters as he prepared to depart Ireland on Sunday after a two-day trip that mixed diplomatic meet-

ings with attending the Amgen Irish Open golf tournament at his resort in Doonbeg, County Clare.

"Well, I like the candidate from Illinois. He's a good man," Trump said, recounting Bailey's personal tragedy of losing his son Zachary, his daughter-in-law Kelsey and two of their children in a helicopter crash in Montana last October.

After the crash, Trump wrote Bailey a letter of condolence and told the downstate farmer and former state lawmaker, who at the time was still deciding whether to run in the GOP primary for governor, to "continue to Fight! Fight! Fight! for your beloved state in honor of your beautiful family!"

Trump, who in 2022 endorsed



Darren Bailey, right, the Republican candidate for governor, walks the Septemberfest Labor Day Parade in Schaumburg on Sept. 7.

JOHN STARKS/DAILY HERALD

See **GOVERNOR** on Page A6

SUBSCRIPTION

Visit myaccount.chicagotribune.com or call 312-546-7900 to sign up for a subscription. To place an ad, visit placeanad.chicagotribune.com.

WEATHER FORECAST

TODAY H: 82 L: 66
WED. H: 72 L: 68
THU. H: 77 L: 67

FULL WEATHER REPORT, PAGE A14

INDEX

Almanac A11
Arts & Living B7
Business B1
Comics B10-11
Crossword B11
Editorials A8
Horoscope B10
Nation & World B4
Television B9

179th year No. 258
© Chicago Tribune

7 49485 00001 2